

work, as long as you're promoting it. The only way you can promote your podcast is through creating a social media presence. Podcasts don't play the numbers game, they play the quality game – so build a community around your show, get to know your audience and garner their loyalty.

What is the minimum viable setup?

Mae: Plan, plan, plan. Give yourself a budget for your show, whatever you can afford. If it's online, make sure you have a decent mic/headphone setup and record on a reliable podcast recording software – Riverside, Squadcast, Zencaster, Descript – not Zoom or Google Meet, which is conferencing software and not good quality for online recordings. If you need to use a good recording studio, they can range from ₹600 to ₹3,000 per hour. The engineers in these studios can edit your show too, so you can ask them how much it costs and incorporate that into your budget. If this gets to be too much, at least get them to create the opening and closing packaging for your show so you can have that as a template for each episode going forward. Also, my advice to any creator starting out: pull all the favours you can from anyone you know. You can't be shy when you're creating and there is no shame in asking for help.

What should someone do before publishing the first episode?

Mae: Before you record anything, before you switch on your mic, make sure you have a good idea. Tell someone – a friend or family or colleague or your chaiwalla – about your show. They should be enamoured and think, gosh, I want to hear that. Do a test pilot of your show. It helps you understand what your show will sound like and troubleshoots all your problems. Once you've made the pilot and figured out the template of your show, record a few episodes and bank at least two to three months' worth. When you decide to launch,

I think one of the biggest mistakes hosts make is not being themselves. A lot of the time, people think that they need to be 'a version of a host' when they just need to be authentically who they are naturally. Another aspect of interviewing in particular is people don't realise that you're listening more than you speak as a host.

make sure you're comfortable with your release plan – episodes ready, descriptions and artwork good to go, promotional materials and campaign done. Don't launch your podcast while you're at vipassana. Make sure you're focused and not distracted during this time.

With no famous guests and no following, what actually helps discovery?

Mae: Now that is the ultimate question and truly the hardest one to answer. Discovery is the biggest problem of podcasting. Make your show available on all platforms – Apple, Spotify, Amazon Music, JioSaavn, YouTube. Even if your show isn't a video show, create a YouTube feed, because YouTube is the second largest search engine on the internet. Create a social media plan, even if you're starting from zero. Create the short form clips, the newsletter, the press release, the carousel posts – everything. Get your mother to share it on her college WhatsApp group. Promote it and share it like your life depends on it.

When should a podcaster think about monetisation?

Mae: Monetisation happens when you

have a significant or loyal audience. Even if it's 1,000 listeners, you've interacted with them and they are responding. Based on my own experience and general industry standards, the rough benchmarks would be: new podcasts, 100–150 downloads per episode in 30 days is typical. Top 1% of podcasts, 35k+ downloads per episode. Average completion rate is 50–75%, and strong retention is 60%+. So download metrics are not the only measure of a successful show. It's the quality of the audience and their consumption patterns that are key. A podcast with 500 listeners and 70% retention which is your exact target demographic is far more valuable than 10,000 casual or passive listeners.

Is the pursuit of viral clips pushing podcasters away from audio craft?

Mae: Yes. Yes, it is pushing podcasters away from creating in audio. Visually, video podcasts are so boring – one person in front of a mic, talking to another person on a mic. Eye roll. The craft of audio has definitely not been fully explored in India, and I will always champion audio.

What does India's podcast ecosystem still lack?

Mae: Discoverability. I've spoken to podcast industry folks in the US, UK, UAE, Malaysia, China, Australia and even Romania, and discoverability remains an issue across the board. There are now millions of podcasts and hundreds of millions of episodes available globally. Yet most listeners can probably name fewer than ten podcasts they've ever listened to. This is not a content problem. This is a discovery problem. My next mission is not just about creating podcasts but forging new paths to discovery – through recommendation, curation, community-engagement, culture-building. The algorithm isn't enough. We now need to meet audiences where they are at. 